

APPOSITIVES

Appositives are nouns or noun phrases that rename another noun or noun phrase.

They set up a special table on which they display seven foods with names beginning with the letter *s* in Persian, **the language of Iran**.

In this sentence, *Persian* and *the language of Iran* are the same thing. *The language of Iran* is an appositive.

Appositives are helpful in writing definitions because they give the reader more information about your topic concisely (without a lot of extra words).

Fudge, **a soft creamy candy**, was invented as a result of a cooking mistake.

Appositives can contain necessary information or extra information. (Some grammar books call necessary information *restrictive* and extra information *nonrestrictive*.)

Consider this sentence:

My friend **Tina** makes incredible chocolate fudge.

In this sentence, *Tina* is an appositive because *Tina* and *my friend* are the same person. *Tina* is a necessary appositive because it is necessary to identify which friend makes incredible chocolate fudge. If we omit the word *Tina*, we don't know which friend makes the fudge.

Now consider this sentence:

Tina, my friend, makes incredible chocolate fudge.

In this sentence, the appositive is *my friend*. It is extra information because the name *Tina* already identifies the person who makes incredible fudge. If we omit *my friend*, we still know who makes the candy. The fact that she is the writer's friend is not necessary to identify her. It is merely extra information.

If an appositive follows a name, further identification is unnecessary. Similarly, adjectives such as *first*, *last*, *best*, *worst*, *favorite*, *tallest*, *oldest*, and *most interesting* automatically make a noun one of a kind, so the appositive is extra information.

Tina usually gives me chocolate walnut fudge for my favorite holiday of the year, **Valentine's Day**.

The appositive *Valentine's Day* is extra information because it follows *favorite holiday of the year*, and there can be only one "favorite."

I have three sons. My son **Carlos** looks like me.

Carlos is necessary information because there are three sons, and the name *Carlos* is necessary to identify which son.

My oldest son, **Javier**, looks like his father.

The appositive *Javier* is extra information because there can be only one oldest son.

Comma Rules for Appositives

Use commas to separate an extra information appositive from the rest of the sentence. Do not use commas with necessary appositives.

NECESSARY Magazine editor **Sarah Josepha Hale** helped make Thanksgiving a national holiday in the United States.

EXTRA Sarah Josepha Hale, **a magazine editor**, helped make Thanksgiving a national holiday in the United States.

Writing Tip

To figure out whether to use commas with an appositive, remove the appositive from the sentence. If the sentence still makes sense, use commas around the appositive. If the sentence doesn't make sense, don't use commas.

PRACTICE 7

Identifying and Punctuating Appositives

Underline the appositive in each sentence. Write *NI* if the appositive gives *necessary information*. Write *EI* if it gives *extra information*. Add commas around the unnecessary appositives.

- NI 1. The movie *Groundhog Day* arrived in theaters in 1993.
- EI 2. Bill Murray, a talented comedian, is the star of the movie.
- _____ 3. In the movie, Bill Murray is meteorologist Phil Connors.
- _____ 4. Phil Connors has to go to Punxsutawney a small town in the mountains of western Pennsylvania.
- _____ 5. On February 2, Punxsutawney has a celebration for Groundhog Day an old mid-winter holiday.
- _____ 6. Phil Connors and his coworker Rita plan to stay in Punxsutawney for just 24 hours.
- _____ 7. The worst kind of winter weather a blizzard forces Phil and Rita to remain in Punxsutawney.
- _____ 8. Romantic comedies funny movies about love always have a happy ending, and Phil and Rita's February 2 story does, too.



Task 1: Add appositives into the following nouns to further explain each:

- Cancer.....
- Mark Zuckerberg.....
- Apple.....
- The popular holiday in Vietnam
- One of my relatives.....

CHAPTER 6

DEFINITION PARAGRAPHS

OBJECTIVES

To write academic texts, you need to master certain skills.

In this chapter, you will learn to:

- Identify and produce clear definitions
- Use appositives correctly
- Identify and write complex sentences with adjective clauses
- Use commas around extra information
- Write, revise, and edit a paragraph that defines a word, concept, or custom



INTRODUCTION

In Chapter 5, you learned about how-to paragraphs. Chapter 6 focuses on writing a **definition paragraph**—one that gives a clear definition. Such paragraphs are common in academic writing. For example, tests of general writing ability sometimes ask you to define an abstract term such as *love*, *friendship*, *courage*, or *happiness*. (Something abstract cannot be touched or seen; it exists only in a person's mind.) On other academic tests, you may have to define a special term in a specific subject area, for instance:

BUSINESS What is the payback period?

COMPUTER SCIENCE What is a LAN? Who uses a LAN, and what is its purpose?

U.S. HISTORY What was the Underground Railroad?

HEALTH SCIENCES What is the Rh factor, and why is it important?

In addition, people may ask you to define a word in your first language that they have heard but do not fully understand, such as *machismo* in Spanish, *joie de vivre* in French, or *Gemütlichkeit* in German. They may also ask you to explain an interesting custom or practice such as *Casual Friday* or *Saint Patrick's Day* in the United States, *O-bon* festivals in Japan, *holi* festivals in India, or *quinceañera* parties in Spanish-influenced cultures. At the end of Chapter 6, you will write a paragraph that defines a word, concept, or custom.

ANALYZING THE MODEL

The writing model gives a definition of courage.

Read the model. Then answer the questions.

Writing Model



Courage

1 Courage is the quality of being brave in a dangerous or difficult situation. 2 The word *courage* comes from the Latin *cor*, meaning "heart." 3 Courageous people have big hearts. 4 They go the distance for what they believe in, despite the risks. 5 We all can think of courageous people from history. 6 Take American astronaut Neil Armstrong, for instance. 7 He bravely faced life-threatening situations during the *Gemini 8* and *Apollo 11* space voyages and became the first human to walk on the moon. 8 Nelson Mandela, the former president of South Africa, also exhibited enormous courage. 9 He put everything on the line to fight for racial equality in his home country. 10 However, courage is not confined to famous people. 11 For example, a soldier who goes into battle shows courage. 12 A firefighter who crawls into a collapsed building to help an injured person also shows courage. 13 Then there are the acts of bravery that take place in everyday life. 14 For instance, a shy person who confronts the fear of public speaking and gives a speech is courageous. 15 A teenager who resists peer pressure to smoke, drink, or try drugs is extremely brave. 16 We all have friends or family members who have shown courage. 17 My friend Angela, who is terrified of flying, recently took her first airplane flight. 18 As she was about to walk onto the plane, she was trembling from head to toe, but she didn't allow herself to go to pieces. 19 She faced her fear and was glad she did. 20 In my book, Angela has a lot in common with the bravest people in the world.

Questions about the Model

1. Find the topic sentence. What is the topic? Circle the word or a thing that the writer defines.
2. In a definition paragraph, the definition is the controlling idea. What is the writer's controlling idea about the topic? Underline it.
3. What kinds of information does the writer give to support the controlling idea?

1. TOPIC SENTENCE IN A DEFINITION PARAGRAPH

One way to write a topic sentence for a definition paragraph is to give three pieces of information:

1. The word or thing you will define or explain (the topic)
2. The large category or group to which the word or thing belongs
3. The distinguishing characteristics that make the word or thing different from other members of the category

TERM/PERSON/CONCEPT	CATEGORY OR GROUP	DISTINGUISHING CHARACTERISTICS
Courage is . . .	the quality . . .	of being brave in a dangerous or difficult situation.
Casual Friday refers to . . .	the custom . . .	of office workers wearing casual clothes to work on Fridays.
The Underground Railroad was . . .	a secret network . . .	that helped enslaved people in the United States escape from the South to freedom in the North during the mid-1800s.

PRACTICE 3

Choosing a Topic Sentence for a Definition Paragraph

Read the definition paragraph. Circle the best topic sentence in the list. Then write it on the line.

Degrees Fahrenheit

_____ The name *Fahrenheit* comes from German scientist Daniel Gabriel Fahrenheit, who created a new way of measuring temperature in 1724. In his system, water freezes at 32 degrees Fahrenheit and boils at 212 degrees Fahrenheit. The Fahrenheit scale was used in science, industry, and everyday life for many years, especially in English-speaking countries. However, by the 1970s, Celsius had become the standard measurement of temperature in most parts of the world. The United States is one of the few countries that continues to use the Fahrenheit scale today. International visitors who are in the United States can understand Fahrenheit temperatures by using one of two basic formulas: $F = 9/5 \times C + 32$ or $C = 5/9 \times (F - 32)$. Even better, they can use one of the digital convertors available online and on devices such as smart phones to see Fahrenheit and Celsius measurements side by side.

- a. Fahrenheit is measurement system.
- b. Fahrenheit is a scale that is used to measure temperature.
- c. The Fahrenheit system is used in the United States.
- d. On the Fahrenheit temperature scale, water freezes at 32 degrees.

PRACTICE 4**Completing Topic Sentences for Definition Paragraphs**

Work with a partner. Complete each topic sentence for a definition paragraph with (1) a category or group word and (2) a distinguishing characteristic. Use a dictionary as needed.

1. A dictator is a ruler who has all the power in a country.
2. An optimist is _____ who _____.
3. Chess is _____ that _____.

2. SENTENCE THAT EXPLAINS THE MEANING OF THE TERM IN A DEFINITION PARAGRAPH

PRACTICE 1**Exploring a Word's History**

Work with a partner or in a small group. Use a dictionary to look up the origins of the words *astronaut*, *astronomy*, *asterisk*, *nautilus*, and *nautical*. Then answer the questions.

1. What does *astro* mean? _____
2. What does *naut* mean? _____
3. So, who does “an astronaut” refer to?

4. Write the full definition of the word “Astronaut”

3. SUPPORTING SENTENCES IN A DEFINITION PARAGRAPH

The supporting sentences of a definition paragraph present details that explain the topic more completely. The supporting sentences may give additional facts telling *who*, *what*, *where*, *when*, *how*, or *why*. They may also provide an explanation of a process, examples, or a description.

Casual Friday became popular in the United States and Canada in the late 1990s and early 2000s.

Offices have rules about what employees can and cannot wear, but there is some freedom of choice on Friday.

Workers usually feel more comfortable when they wear clothes like jeans and a casual shirt instead of a business suit.

PRACTICE 5

Identifying the Kind of Support in a Definition Paragraph

Read the paragraph. Underline the supporting sentences. Then circle the word or phrase in the list that best describes the supporting sentences.

Portable Memory

A flash drive is a device for storing or moving digital files. It is also called a USB drive, thumb drive, jump drive, or pen drive. No matter what it is called, the device is the same. A flash drive is similar to a small computer hard drive. However, it has no moving parts, and it can be easily removed and carried in a pocket, in a bag, or on a keychain. A flash drive usually connects to a computer through a USB port and comes in a variety of shapes, sizes, and colors. Because it is convenient and reliable, a flash drive is now a standard piece of computer equipment.

- | | |
|-----------------------|---------------------------|
| a. steps in a process | c. facts and descriptions |
| b. reasons | d. narrative details |

4. CONCLUDING SENTENCE IN A DEFINITION PARAGRAPH

In the concluding sentence of a definition paragraph, you may tell why the topic is important, interesting, or unique.

In my book, Angela has a lot in common with the bravest people in the world.

Casual Friday lets office employees relax while they continue working on the last day of the workweek.

The Underground Railroad is an important part of the history of the United States.

Read the paragraph. Circle the best conclusion in the list. Then write it on the line.

Entrepreneurs

An entrepreneur is a person who takes a risk and makes money from a business that is new and different. An excellent example of an entrepreneur is Mark Zuckerberg, one of the creators of Facebook. He and several of his friends started the social networking site while they were students at Harvard University. Facebook changed the way that people communicate, and Zuckerberg became a billionaire. Another entrepreneurial success is Mrs. Fields, a bakery that was the first of its kind. Unlike shops that had cakes, pies, bread, and other baked goods, Mrs. Fields sold only cookies when it opened in 1977. Business experts predicted that Debbie Fields would never succeed, but she refused to fail. Entrepreneur Ingvar Kamprad began his business career in 1926 by selling matches to his neighbors at the age of five. He opened his first IKEA store when he was 17 with money that his father gave him for being a good student. As a result of his ideas about selling furniture and home goods at reasonable prices, there are now IKEA stores around the globe. _____

- a. Entrepreneurs share similar qualities. They are smart people who know how to make a lot of money.
- b. Entrepreneurs are very much alike. They are people who want to make a lot of money as quickly as possible.
- c. As these three examples show, entrepreneurs are well-educated people. Their education is the key to their success.
- d. These three examples show that entrepreneurs share a common characteristic. They are not afraid to take chances.

WRITING PRACTICE

Fill in the following paragraph with your own ideas to provide a whole definition of the word **"HAPPINESS"**. Use the cues below to guide you through the brainstorming process:

- The topic sentence includes the word, the category, and its brief meaning.
- The second sentence explains its origin
- The supporting sentences point out the factors that contribute to a happy life (explained through real-life examples)
- The essay ends with your personal opinion of happiness.

Happiness is a _____ that points to _____, and it can be briefly defined as _____. This concept originally comes from _____, which suggests that happiness is closely connected to _____. Over time, people have developed different ideas about happiness based on their experiences and values.

In everyday life, there are several important factors that contribute to a happy life. One major factor is _____. For instance, when people _____, they often feel more satisfied and positive about their lives. Another contributing factor is _____, which can be clearly seen in situations where _____. In addition, _____ also plays an essential role in creating happiness, such as when _____. These examples show that happiness is not only about _____ but also about _____.

In my personal opinion, happiness means _____. I believe this because _____, and this understanding helps me _____ in my daily life.